

online presence nowadays, and it's really easy to do a Google search and get one's name, alias, contact number and address, contributing to the menace that is cyber stalking. As the internet is increasingly becoming an integral part of our personal and professional lives, stalkers can take advantage of the ease of communications and the availability of personal information only a few mouse clicks away. In addition, the anonymous and non-confrontational nature of internet communications further tosses away any disincentives in the way of cyber stalking.

Cyber stalking is done in two primary ways:

- ▶ **Internet Stalking:** Here the stalker harasses the victim via the internet. Unsolicited email is the most common way of threatening someone, and the stalker may even send obscene content and viruses by email. However, viruses and unsolicited telemarketing email alone do not constitute cyber stalking. But if email is sent repeatedly in an attempt to intimidate the recipient, they may be considered as stalking. Internet stalking is not limited to email; stalkers can more comprehensively use the internet to harass the victims. Any other cyber-crime that we've already read about, if done with an intention to threaten, harass, or slander the victim may amount to cyber stalking.
- ▶ **Computer Stalking:** The more technologically advanced stalkers apply their computer skills to assist them with the crime. They gain unauthorised control of the victim's computer by exploiting the working of the internet and the Windows operating system. Though this is usually done by proficient and computer savvy stalkers, instructions on how to accomplish this are easily available on the internet.

Cyber stalking has now spread its wings to social networking. With the increased use of social media such as Facebook, Twitter, Flickr and YouTube, your profile, photos, and status updates are up for the world to see. Your online presence provides enough information for you to become a potential victim of stalking without even being aware of the risk. With the "check-ins", the "life-events", apps which access your personal information and the need to put up just about everything that you're doing and where you're doing it, one doesn't really leave anything for the stalkers to figure out for themselves. Social networking technology provides a social and collaborative platform for internet users to interact, express their thoughts and share almost everything about their lives. Though it promotes socialisation amongst people, along the way it contributes to the rise of internet violations.